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Following its creation in 1945, the United Nations General Assembly has functioned as the most prominent multilateral platform in the world where governments project narratives about foreign policy, identity, and global order. U.S. presidents are no exception, as each has sought to project an image of American soft power through narratives of leadership, responsibility, and strategic vision for the international community. Drawing on Searle's theory about *performative acts,* political language is much more than rhetorical tool, it enhances commitment, and shapes international expectation.(Searle, 1969). Applied to international relations, and international politics, this would mean that presidential rhetoric is a political act that legitimizes the presidential policy and choices, by structuring the meaning. (Krebs&Jackson 2007). In the context of American Foreign Policy, UNGA speeches are much more than symbolic tools to express a voice in the international arena, it shapes the decision-making process of the international community as a whole. Yet, the world today is no longer the world of 1945, nor—in several key respects—that of the post–Cold War era. The context of the speeches have evolved and it is also clearly visible in our essay theme : the past decade has been marked by growing skepticism towards multilateralism, challenging the legitimacy, in a time where rivalries are growing. In this essay, we will examine how the UNGA speeches, of the last 4 presidents of the USA, from Barack Obama, to Trump 2.0, articulate contrasting visions of world order, sovereignty, security, and economic governance. This analysis highlights an ongoing oscillation between international engagement and disengagement.

First from Barack Obama (2009-2016), who represents the pinnacle of liberal internationalism, emphasizing the rule of law, multilateral treaties, and collective action. His speeches invoked universal values—human rights, democracy, sustainable development—as foundations for global stability. On the other hand, from 2016, a major shift occurred in rhetorical politics. The *America First* doctrine of 2016 campaign, criticised the UN, and presented national sovereignty as the supreme law of international order. Therefore, liberal institutionalism is challenged, placing the United States as a victim of International Order, and globalization. Biden's presidency aimed to restore US leadership in the international community, via collective problem solving solutions, not out of altruism, but because the rhetoric was, that global challenges require, global solutions. As of January 2025, Trump second term, indicate the continuation of Trump 1.0 towards skepticism of global governance, even though the context of 2025 is very much different than the context of 2016 election : China is stronger, the Indo-Pacific allies pressure and ongoing conflicts, such as the war in Ukraine, makes the break of international cooperation impossible. Our essay will try to stay true to this oscillation between liberal institutionalism, multilateral cooperation, and sovereign nationalism at an international level in the rhetoric of US presidents, from Obama to Trump 2.0. Our main objective is to understand how the US rhetoric has responded to major global shifts and whether the path towards minilateralism is an irreversible transition. For this, our main thesis, will argue that US presidential UNGA speeches oscillate between liberal multilateralism and nationalist sovereigntism, and concerning Trump 2.0, it represents continuity with Trump 1.0 in rhetoric, but structural constraints (allies, China, crises) moderate absolute rupture.

John Ruggie (1992), defines multilateralism as a partnership of international relations between three or more states, but, *on the basis of generalized principles of conduct.* This implies ruled based behaviour, clearly defined and most importantly, a cooperation, in a framework pre-established. It is also needed, to be complete, to define what is liberal institutionalism, because it will be a constant base of our essay. Rooted in Woodrow Wilson's ideas, this theory argues that institutions facilitate cooperation, stabilizing the international system, transforming what John Ikenberry describes, as 'raw power' into 'consensual leadership'. At the UNGA, presidential rhetoric as a tool for shaping norms, defining threats, justifying policies, and signaling commitments that contribute to this form of "consensual leadership. American hegemony leadership is thus exercised through more engagement at the international level. This aligns with Barnett and Finnemore's (2004) view that international organizations both shape and are shaped by global discourses. However, this conceptual framework is challenged by contemporary societies, with the emergence of *minilateralism,* operating outside universal multilateral frameworks*,* such as the UN, the IMF, UNESCO etc… and a system that no longer reflects the '*zeitgeist'.* Rather than listing U.S. presidencies chronologically, this paper conducts a comparative analysis of UNGA speeches across four analytical dimensions: First, we will focus on the vision of the world order (narrative), then the struggle between multilateralism and sovereignty, that is a constant dimension. The two last, but not least dimensions, will examine the so-called 'security framing' and the economic governance, always through the lens of the UNGA speeches of our presidencies.

Regarding the vision of the world order, Obama articulated a liberal-internationalist narrative. Months after his election, back in 2009, he declared that "*the U.S cannot solve the challenges of our time alone" [and must pursue] global responses to global challenges.".* While it would be simplistic to sum-up Obama's mandate only to this statement, the rhetoric emphasized the theory supported by John Ikenberry model of Liberal Order (2011) is constant: the use of the liberal order (rules, alliances, and institutions such as the UN) as an instrument of leadership. As outlined in the theoretical framework, the general principles of multilateral conduct identified by Ruggie are clearly reflected in this discourse. We present cooperation as a multilateral solution, to collective actions solving problems. But, it all changed in 2017. Trump's election, rejected Obama's principle of global cooperation and engagement. He denounced the famously known Paris 2015 Agreement, and made a clear statement towards international community : From now on, a general skepticism will overlook the international system (Mearsheimer,2018) and will make *realism theory* in practice : International system, will be considered as a competitive arena, rather than a shared global system. Biden's presidency from 2021, signaled a rhetorical return to liberal internationalism. It must also be said, that US global politics, are very much, bipolarized, in the Party depending if you are a Democrat or a Republican, global shifts will be made, even though, the global trend towards unilateralism, or, 'minilateralism', seems to be global, and resisting to party apparatus. What Obama warned in 2016, months before the election, "*a nation ringed by walls would only imprison itself*" seems if not to take place, shifting towards a more unilateral world even though Biden presidency towards climate governance, global

health in the post-Pandemic world, tried to curb this global dynamic of damage towards multilateralism and multilateralism.

Anticipated Trump 2.0 discourse—derived from campaign addresses and policy declarations by figures such as Pete Hegseth, J.D. Vance, Karoline Leavitt, and Donald Trump himself—indicates a persistent alignment with sovereigntist ideals. His denunciation of "globalist initiatives" reflects his 2017 UNGA communication. Nevertheless, as highlighted by Burke-White (2021), the current strategic landscape presents greater limitations: the competition between China and the United States, instability in the Middle East, and fluctuations in energy supply are expected to compel Trump 2. 0 to favor *'selective unilateralism'* over a completely unilateral approach—balancing rhetoric with geopolitical realism. The tension between sovereignty and multilateralism is not new in U.S history, however, it has been exponentially intensified in the Trump 1.0 and Trump 2.0 era. Unilateral tariffs imposed by the Trump 2.0 administration clearly illustrate this shift : a shift from Sovereignty through cooperation towards the so-called '*Hard Sovereignty'* has been complete. During Obama's rule, sovereignty paved the way to cooperation, asserting in a speech made in 2014, that *"Real leadership means building coalitions."*. This framing aligns with Keohane's meaning that the mean is to transform 'absolute sovereignty' into 'effective sovereignty' but only through the pre-existing institutions, whereas for Trump 1.0, institutions are a threat to national autonomy, and therefore, sovereignty pass through deconstructing all the pre-existing norms, as explained by Patrick (2017). We have multiple examples, such as the Paris Climate Accord, and UNESCO in 2017, or the Trans-Pacific Partnership in 2020. This era is marked, by vigorous attacks, in discourse to these institutions, via press conferences, but echoes to nowadays also times, in Trump 2.0 presidency, when president J.D Vance, addressed in Munich in February 2025, the future of Europe, in a multilateral setting, or, more recently, back in September 2025, warning in the UN, that Western countries were "going to hell" because of migration and calling climate change a "con job", or concerning the UN efficiency saying that *"All they seem to do is write a really strongly worded letter, [...]It's empty words, and empty words don't solve war."* constituting a violent attack on multilateralism. Thus, Trump 2.0 may combine sovereigntism with selective coalition-building, producing a hybrid minilateral approach.

Again, the study of speeches allows us to go back to the narratives of how the US sees its own foreign policy, with potential threats, alliances and the meaning of the use of force going back and forth between cooperation and rhetorical grievances towards the UN system often judged unbalanced. Obama, again, in the continuity of world order views, will see security as a collective action problem, engaging with two long lasting 'enemies' : Iran and North Korea. His emphasis on burden-sharing, peacekeeping reform, and humanitarian responsibility aligns with cooperative security literature (Kupchan & Kupchan 1995) and R2P doctrine (Bellamy 2015). We cannot say the same with Donald Trump first term and ultimately even more in the second term primarily assessment : labilling the leader of Republic Democratic North Korea, Kim Jong Un, of a '*Rocket Man on a suicide mission'* and threatening *'to totally destroy North Korea'* during a UN Session. We are in what Schelling calls a *'coercive diplomacy'* (Schelling, 1966), notably through military and deterrence strategies through Trump 1. Biden's look towards security was much more complex and

interdependent. In a speech given back in 2021, he intertwined security, and stability : *"Our security, prosperity, and freedoms are interconnected".* The special time of pandemic, the growing risk of technological and cyber threats and climate risks, made international politics post pandemic change, aligning with new security studies, such as Barry Buzan. (Buzan, 2003). Again, the 2024 election, and the intronization of the Trump 2.0 era, seemed to change dynamics. Large Scale interventions, are yet again, constrained to a secondary and hypothetical role. Yet, assertiveness, towards Iran and China, seems to be here, in a more targeted hard-power diplomacy, and building a minilateral security architecture with individual actors, more than with global entities (such as the European Union). One more element is needed, to assess this primary Trump 2.0 era, compared to the past democrat presidential 'hegemony' from 2008 to 2020. How about the economic global governance in the multilateral environment ? What ideas from US president speeches can we extract from economic governance, promoting a certain kind of model, from economic multilateralism to protectionism ?

The same tendency occurs. The UN General Assembly is the stage where the number one economy in the world, with a nominal PIB, estimated at 27 Billion USD, tends to spread its model in a ruled-based economic multilateralism. Obama defended open markets, global trade, and coordinated responses to economic crises. In 2016, he advocated for the TPP (trans-pacific partnership) and warned against protectionist retrenchment. This is again, a clear example of Keohane and Nye's Institutionalist Trade Theory, for free trade (1977). However, again, in Trump 's first term, in the rhetoric that America is getting used and had no advantages,Trump criticised the WTO for the lack of defense of America's interest. Therefore he probes a more nationalist economy, putting *America First,* in a more unilateral way- with tariffs, notably, entering a new protectionist cycle. The swings in all our essays can be summed up by the term cycles. The primary assessment of Trump 2.0, would represent a new cycle for America, with a more protective economy, in a more protectionist multilateralism, a sort of *a la carte* arrangements. Multilateralism, is therefore again, challenged in its own institutions, such as the IMF, or the WTO. Biden's terms, promoting calibrated globalization, and a more balanced system, will not challenge this broad dynamic, as America entered a new economic cycle. Trump's 2024–2025 proposals—universal tariffs, strategic decoupling from China—suggest a deepening of protectionist logic, even with the so-called longest allies, such as Europe. One of the clearest assessments that we can make in this Trump 2.0 Era, is that, economically, the international economic discourse of Donald J Trump, did not vary : it will be America first, and Europe, relegated as a simple commercial partner, only if Europe, complies with the rules, settled by the own American Administration.

As recalled by Kofi Annan in his rapport and speech on UN reform in 2005, "*we need less rhetoric and more multilateral cooperation if we want global stability".* It was true in 2005, and it is even more true twenty years after. However, if we take a closer look to US Presidential speech, from Barack Obama to Donald Trump the second term, made in UNGA, reveals precisely, the tension between internal and systemic system, running through American leadership, oscillating between engaging multilateralism, to skepticism towards multilateral sittings. This oscillation is not a simple exception of 21st century US multilateral

politics : it reflects the internal vivid debate, with a growing polarization of American society, and a functional change in multilateral setting, getting more and more competitive, a growing scale of conflict and less stability. As observed and used in the essay, John Ikenberry (2011) showed that American Liberal Institutionalism will not disappear, but reconfigure itself, notably through discourses, and in this case presidential discourse. Concerning Trump 2.0, following this statement, it is more a continuity than a rough shift of global sovereignty rhetorical tools used in Trump 1.0, with key themes emerging, such as global skepticism and distrust, national preference, and a multilateral setting, understood as transactional relationships, maybe, coring, the key feature of President Donald J. Trump, being at his core, a business man, more than a politician. Geopolitical Constraints (China, Russia-Ukraine, and North-Korea) will remodule the way that we perceive US presidential rhetorics, but not the substance. The way to minilateralism is the way US foreign policy seems to go, particularly in Donald Trump 2.0 era. However, it would be simplistic, to define this characteristic, as a trumpist. These trends, in US foreign policy, accelerated in the Trump 2.0 era, but were already here, in Joe Biden's presidency. John Ruggie (1992), notes institutional form of multilateralism is sensitive to power transformations: the United States therefore adjusts its practices without totally abandoning the multilateral scale. To sum up, I would personally argue that UNGA speeches, from 2009 to 2025, have continuity in transformation : The United States of America, stay bonded and engaged and committed to International multilateral setting, but in a more selective way and redrawing from the traditional unconditional support to multilateral institutions, drawing a tension. The solution, that seems to be implemented, is a hybrid one : International Politics will still be a priority for US politics, in a more selective, strategic and conditional way. The Trump 2.0 presidency stays true to this statement, and as a global trend, we are more into swings in international politics than continuities.

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